

READING IN A SECOND LANGUAGE: PROCESS, PRODUCT AND PRACTICE

Sandy Urquhart & Cyril Weir



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Reading in a Second Language

APPLIED LINGUISTICS AND LANGUAGE STUDY

GENERAL EDITOR

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Reading in a Second Language: Process, Product and Practice

A.H. Urquhart and C.J. Weir

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Process, Product and Practice
A.H. URQUHART *and* C.J. WEIR

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General Editor's preface

The subtitle of this new contribution to the *Applied Linguistics and Language Study Series* is significant. Reading is a matter of interaction. Products for reading in the form of texts are not only themselves outcomes of writer processes, cognitive, linguistic, and social, but invite and activate those processes in their readers. Not that the engagement of writer and reader only begins when the reader picks up or otherwise accesses a text. Writers always have readers in mind, and we know that expert writers tailor their writing to their readers' presumed cognitive and linguistic capacities, partly by establishing some common social context for the interaction. We may trace in writing evidence of the degree to which this accommodation takes place, and by monitoring reading processes we can appraise its effectiveness. Thus, as readers evaluate writers, so do writers envisage readers. Reading is in this way a kind of sympathetic and unscripted writing. Seen this way, the instructing and appraisal of reading is linked to those of writing, providing an example of how teaching and testing can go hand in hand. They do so explicitly in this innovative book by Sandy Urquhart and Cyril Weir. It is not axiomatic that teaching and testing enjoy this synergy. Indeed, it is often argued that they are adversarial. Testing is held by some to inhibit teaching, or through washback to come to dominate and direct it. Exploring the interaction between teaching and testing is one of the distinctive features of this book.

There are further interactions to be noted. Reading and writing invite in their relationship comparisons between listening and speaking. The authors establish this parallelism in their *Preliminaries* in the first chapter of the book. It is a compelling association since it embraces the cognitive, the linguistic and the social, within

the speaking/listening connection and between that of reading and speaking. Reading, writing, listening and speaking not only interactively involve these processes, they are also in themselves social practices. They occur in contexts. The authors are sensitive to this but they are also cautious. They warn against too easy an assumption of transfer from one context to another. Reading in one context may not be the same as in another, and transferability and generalisability of effective reading strategies cannot be taken for granted. Testing is one way in which we may explore this issue. Here, too, testing and teaching are interlinked.

Reading as a social practice is, however, not only a little 'c' context matter. As a social practice it always also invokes the bigger 'C' Context, what sociologists refer to as the institutional matrices within which particular reading practices are embedded. Such ways of going about reading contribute to our understanding of the role reading plays in the definition of the institution as a particular social and cultural world. The receptive conditions governing the act of reading are important, as are the productive conditions governing writing. The experience and expertise of the authors is crucial at this point, as elsewhere in the book. Their close familiarity with the contexts and Contexts of reading ensures that there is no light assumption of transferability, nor any ignoring of the impact of the social interactivity of reading on its cognitive interactivity within the reader. Nonetheless, exploring reading from the perspective of mind and that of social relationships requires discrete discussion. Here the interplay in the book among theoretical, instructional and evaluative concepts and practices allows each its place, but, in the end, they interact. They do more than that. They are expressly positioned in the book to engage each other. Theories and models of reading and their components are tested against the constraints imposed by testing, and against the exigencies of instruction. Readers of the book are thus not led up some garden path. Nor are they allowed to forget that reading, as I say earlier, is essentially an engagement with text. How one describes such texts, as a reading specialist or as a testing specialist, will not be the same as if one described the text from the perspective of a linguist or a cognitive psychologist, or indeed as a sociologist. This is not always fully appreciated. Grammar is not disciplinarily neutral. The authors recognise this. Indeed, they are very explicit about boundaries in this case, as the

section on *Future Research* makes clear. Nevertheless, they do not isolate these perspectives in practice. How one processes the grammar of a text does have some connection with the way the text is structured grammatically. Grammar, after all, acts to stimulate particular processes of exploring meaning potential.

Understanding such processes requires us to accommodate different strategies and styles of reading. There is no one way of reading a text, and reading variability depends on a range of factors: what one is reading, who one is as a reader, who or what one may be reading for and why, what level of linguistic competence one has, what relationships one may have with the writer, and for a host of other reasons. Such a range of variables imposes a challenge to testers, who have their own criteria and standards to meet, ones which urge convergence and normativeness. Thus, analysts of text, analysts of mind, and analysts of social context necessarily interact in the analysis of reading. Adding testing to this mixture causes a redefinition of the roles and boundaries of each. So, too does teaching, but not in the same way. Teaching, after all, is about divergence as well as convergence.

Interaction involves actors. An issue of importance for the book is the tension that arises between considering the reader as individual and the reader as a member of a social group. The authors believe that a current bias towards the social act of reading needs to be corrected so that the cognitive capacity of the reading individual is not lost, and his or her personal contribution to the activity of reading thereby underestimated. Here, again, the individualised focus of testing provides a useful corrective. Not that large scale testing of reading, such as that conducted over several years by expert teams advised by Cyril Weir in the almost ungraspable context of several million testees in China, does not provide some valuable collective and aggregative information. Nonetheless, examination halls, the authors' default environment, are but collections of individuals, whose capacities need personalised assessment, and the enhancement of whose strategies and skills in classrooms through instruction, they conclude, is currently best assessed cognitively rather than socially. Yet, authenticating reading remains a significant instructional goal. It is a measure of the wisdom of this clearly argued and sympathetic book that the authors conclude that it will only be through the interaction of theory, instruction and assessment that the challenge

of this authentication can be addressed in classrooms, or indeed, in examination halls, and the legitimate pressures of the textual, the cognitive and the social can be accommodated by researchers, teachers and testers.

Professor Christopher N Candlin
General Editor
English Language Education and Communication Research
City University of Hong Kong

Introduction

The book is primarily intended for those professionally concerned with the teaching and testing of reading in a foreign language. We take this to include teachers, both practising and in training, teacher-trainers, materials writers, and those concerned with the production of reading tests, or with training testers.

Borrowing a term used by anthropologists and semanticists, we will refer to our *prototypical* teaching situation as an L2 classroom in a school, college or university. This does not mean that we are ignorant of the fact that reading may be taught, or learned, in other contexts, e.g. the home, the workplace, or that a teacher will always be present. We adopt this as our prototype simply in order to establish a point of reference. Similarly, our prototypical testing situation is the examination hall. Again we are fully aware that individuals can test themselves, or, perhaps more important, that classroom teachers can make use of informal tests to check reading performance. Again, though, we need a reference point for the discussion below and throughout the book. We hope that readers will be able to transfer what we say to their own particular situation.

Literacy

The teacher of reading is in the business of attempting to improve literacy. Literacy has been the focus of a great deal of work over the last few decades. By discussing, however briefly, some of this work, we shall hopefully set this book against a broad and meaningful context.

The definition of literacy is crucial (cf. Baynham, 1995 and Venezky et al., 1990). One implied definition, touching in its

optimism, can be found in the US Census of 1940, where a person is judged literate if they are 10 years of age or older and has completed 5 or more years in school (Newman and Beverstock, 1990). For serious discussion nowadays, the starting point must be UNESCO proposals of the 1950s that literacy should be defined in terms of *minimal* and *functional* literacy (see Venezky et al., 1990). The former refers to the ability to read and write a simple message; the latter to a level of literacy sufficiently high for a person to function in a social setting. Prior to this, attempts were made to define what Street (1995: 76) refers to as 'autonomous literacy', that is, literacy divorced from any context. Such a hypothetical level is impossible to establish and is inappropriate in many situations. As Venezky et al. (1990: ix) say:

the diverse communities that make up contemporary America are so variegated that simple dichotomies such as literate-illiterate fail to capture what are real differences in what people know and how they behave in certain situations.

The decision to take into account the social relevance of literacy has been momentous, leading as it has to modern notions of multiple '*literacies*'. The concept can apply both to *attitudes* towards the value of literacy, and to the *role* of literacy in the society as a whole. Street (1995) comments on problems caused by a clash in such values between outside educators and local values in Melanesia and among Amish communities in the USA.

In many parts of modern Western society, illiteracy in an adult is seen as a stigma, which the person concerned is often at pains to disguise. In a novel by Ruth Rendell, a character becomes alienated from society as a result of such subterfuges, grows up devoid of normal social emotions, and eventually murders her employers in order to disguise the fact that she cannot take a message.¹ In contrast, in a well-known article, Fingeret (1983) describes how, in urban communities in the USA, illiteracy is not a stigma, help with filling in forms, etc., being exchanged for other skills like car repairing.² It is likely that large and important cultures exist which view literacy in a way very different from our own. Certainly it has been our experience in the L2 classroom that some students do not seem to view written material as a potential source of information accessible to the individual reader. If this observation is valid, the students' behaviour may be a result of views of the role of literacy in their society. To remedy this, an intensified training in

reading skills may not be sufficient; possibly more generalised approaches to the uses of written material might work.

The different levels of literacy required by different groups can be seen when one considers different occupations or professions in the same society. It seems obvious that different occupations make greater professional demands of the written word than others. Tudge – arguing in *New Scientist* that the population divides into those who like reading and those who do not, and that the education system should take this into account – notes that trainee surgeons do not need to make much use of the printed word (they can rely on video-tapes, computer simulations, etc.) whereas lawyers do (Tudge, 1987). It is also obvious that the required level of professional literacy varies radically over time. It seems likely that, in the last century, plumbers, for example, had comparatively low professional requirements for literacy. This is not likely to be the case now.

L2 students in the language class are often preparing to study on academic or other courses conducted in the L2. Such courses, e.g. engineering, nursing, can be assumed to have their own literacy requirements and criterion levels. It is clearly of vital importance that test and syllabus designers take these different requirements and levels into account. In Chapter 3 we discuss this topic under task- and text-based factors. Particularly in LSP, *Needs Analysis* has long been part of the design of courses (cf. Munby, 1978; Nunan, 1993). It is our opinion, however, that detailed ethnographic case studies of the needs of different study areas have not been conducted, or at least published. The difficulty of conducting such studies should not be underestimated.

Related to this is the notion of *transfer* of literacy from one area to another. Implicit in what has been said above, reading skills acquired in the reading class should be transferred to the student's eventual study area. However, the literature on transfer tends to be pessimistic. Mikulecky (1990) claims that a major misconception in literacy studies is that 'mastering literacy in one context substantially transfers to other contexts', and adds 'Transfer of literacy abilities is severely limited by differences in format, social support networks, and required background information as one moves from context to context' (p. 25). He contrasts 'literacy in schools' involving 'independent reading for answering questions at the end of the chapter, or, on some occasions, carefully studying material to remember, synthesize, or evaluate it [what we later refer to as

“careful local” or “careful global” reading]’ and claims that these activities differ from ‘those used to read a troubleshooting manual on the job or gather information to fill in a form’ (p. 25). Sticht (1980) has also claimed that there is little transfer from general reading ability, and reading in specific situations. He contrasts ‘reading to learn’ in school, with ‘reading to do’ in the workplace, or ‘reading toward a goal of locating information for immediate use that need not be recalled later’. While transfer is always a potential problem, we see behind some of this discussion rather conventional and unimaginative limitations on the types of reading which should be practised in the reading class, and point below (Chapter 4) to a wider range of tasks and behaviours.

Returning now to multiple literacies, the notion extends to individuals. A reader may be highly literate in one area but minimally literate in another. The present authors are not functionally literate with respect to, for example, professional scientific texts, and only marginally so *vis-à-vis* teenage fanzines. The L2 teacher of adults will be familiar with the situation in which students in the class are superior readers in certain professional or other areas. In such cases, common in LSP situations, the teacher clearly must see their role as that of *facilitator* rather than pedagogue.

This aspect of multiple literacy also throws doubt on the concept of the ‘good reader’, often referred to in the research literature. Venezky (1990: 12) argues that ‘Most readers show differing reading abilities across different types of material’, a claim repeated by Urquhart (1996). An implication of this is that, for the L2 reader, we may sometimes need not a single test score but a profile composed of performances on different types of text and task. In Chapter 3 we present evidence from testing to support this view.

What might be viewed as an extreme case of different literacies within the same individual can be seen when the individual moves into a different language area. Venezky draws attention to the immigrant into the USA, illiterate in English but literate in Vietnamese and French; and the reverse, literate Americans who are functionally illiterate when they move to other parts of the world. A large proportion of L2 students in reading classes are already literate in their L1 (but see Wallace, 1988; Williams, 1995). A number of consequences rise from this differential literacy in different languages. The fact that many learners are literate in their L1 but not functionally literate in the L2 is the basis for the notion of ‘transfer of reading skills’ discussed in Chapter 2. More

generally, L1 literacy must be one of the components which readers bring to the task of L2 reading (cf. Bernhardt, 1991b). Bernhardt sees 'literacy' in this sense as consisting of knowledge of texts, etc. However, it must be broader than that, including not just, in many cases, knowledge of script, but also, crucially, knowledge that written text is language, containing messages from other language users.

The scope of the term 'literacy'

When we talked earlier about 'defining literacy', we really meant 'defining levels of literacy'. There is also the question of what precise activities are to be covered by the term. Of recent years, it has been given a wide range of referents. Newman and Beverstock (1990) point out that 'membership of an interpretive community is often referred to as a specific literacy, as when we speak of *computer literacy*...'. They later cite 'civic literacy, prison literacy, workplace literacy' (p. 44). Nor is this just rhetoric. As they point out, 'in Michigan, the definition of literacy is being broadened through testing in five areas: written and oral communication, mathematics and related skills, problem, workplace attitude, and job-seeking abilities' (p. 42). They warn that '(while) the old definitions of literacy were too narrow; some of the new definitions may be too broad. The new and humane . . . definitions of literacy are so profuse that we may be loading the word with burdens of meaning that will eventually negate its usefulness as a working term' (p. 43).

Venezky, viewing literacy as a complex of skills, mentions reading, writing, numeracy and document processing as four skill areas lumped under literacy. Venezky argues that 'reading is clearly primary to any definition of literacy, and, in some sense, the others are secondary' (1990: 9). For numeracy, he suggests that it be constrained to 'those basic numeric operations that are critical for ordinary meaning of print' (p. 8). It is a problem which often emerges during reading test construction. On the whole, we tend to think that numeracy should be treated as a separate skills area, as it often is in British educational debate. Venezky seems to see document processing as a separate skill area, dependent on reading. His reason seems to be statistical, based on low correlations found between performance on 'documents' and on 'prose'. There are hints throughout the literacy debate that the texts being used

to measure literacy are very traditional – ‘stories’, etc. There is nothing in the models considered in Chapter 2 to indicate that ‘document reading’ should differ qualitatively from the reading of prose. We thus have no difficulty in fitting it into what we consider as reading.

Macias (1990) argues against ‘multi-literacies’: ‘... numeracy and document processing, as well as the uses of literacy (primarily writing), become secondary aspects of literacy study, not parts of the definition of literacy.’ With the exception of document processing, we go along with this in practice, though perhaps not in theory. We are concerned in this book with reading, and exclude writing, the second half of the literacy equation. This is in spite of the attractiveness of combining the two activities in realistic tasks. Our reasons are partly pragmatic; it is well known, as is set out in Chapter 3, that using written work to test reading runs the risk of confounding two skills areas. In general, we consider that the two skills areas are distinctive enough to be handled separately, as is conventionally the practice in L2 testing and teaching. Writing is well covered in the comprehensive volume by Grabe and Kaplan (1996). We exclude numeracy, however, because, as is argued in ‘Preliminaries’ (Chapter 1), we consider that the term *reading* is best kept for the processing of written *language*.

Literacy and power

The introduction of cultural context into literacy studies has led many writers to consider the relationship between literacy and power. Fingeret (1990) cites Goody and Watt (1968) to the effect that ‘choices about who reads, what they read, and how they use what they read always have been connected to the distribution of power in a society’. This connection is often seen as negative – one group using literacy to maintain and exercise power over another. Groups accused of doing so include slave owners in nineteenth-century America: slaves in some of the southern states were forbidden to read (Newman and Beverstock, 1990). Missionaries in nineteenth-century Melanesia ‘saw literacy practice as a means simply to conversion and to social control, (and thus) they had no interest in providing any more than was necessary for this bare minimum’ (Street, 1995: 84). This form of control is nicely dubbed ‘domestication’ by Mikulecky (1990: 26). The power group in

our own culture may be the literate majority, which 'secure in its position of dominance, partially attributes its success to literacy and guards entrance into literate domains' (Fingeret, 1990: 35). Finally it may be the centralised state, through its institutions (Gee, 1990).

The antidote to such undesirable aspects of literacy is often seen in 'critical literacy' (cf. Baynam, 1995: 205). Mikulecky cites Kretoivics (1985) to the effect that 'the teaching of a "critical literacy" can enable teachers and students to formulate strategies to change the form, content, and social relations of education with an interest in freedom and democracy' (Mikulecky, 1990: 26). This approach, which is closely related to 'critical discourse analysis' (Fairclough, 1995) and 'critical reading' (Wallace, 1992a), stresses not just decoding a text and processing the meaning, but using the text for the reader's purposes, analysing its presuppositions, and how it works on its readers (cf. Freebody and Luke, 1990). Street (1995) comments that 'teaching awareness of . . . the ways in which literacy practices are sites of ideological contest, is itself already a challenge to the dominant autonomous model that disguises such processes' (p. 137).

The motto of the 'critical' group would seem to be '*It's best to be bolshie*' – a position for which we have a certain amount of sympathy. One can, however, give only limited support. It seems to us that Fairclough's argument that the discourse analyst must be aware of the ideological presuppositions contained in a discourse is essentially valid; we would query, however, whether the aims of analyst and reader are necessarily identical. Then it seems a little rich to insist that literacy is primarily a means of socialisation and acculturation, only to add that the reader should be prepared to analyse and possibly reject the power structures inherent in the society or culture. Again, one cannot and should not, in our view, *always* be a critical reader: the first year biology student reading the textbook recommended by the department might do well to adopt a submissive attitude to its contents (see Chapter 2).³ The nuclear worker reading safety regulations might be wise to restrict any criticism. And if this is true for teaching, it is much more true for testing: the student who rebels against the power structure behind the test is unlikely to obtain a good grade.

There are further problems. Street remarks that 'the student is learning cultural models of identity and personhood, not just how to decode script or to write a particular hand' (1995: 140). We are dubious as to whether the adult students in the L2 classroom are

learning 'cultural models of identity', and we are certain that in most instances they are not learning 'models of personhood'. They come into the class bringing their own models of culture, and are often very capable of identifying ideologies in discourses which conflict with their own cultural values.

There is also the problem of the teacher or test writer's own ideological position. Street remarks that the Freireian approach, whereby literacy is accompanied by revolt,

is vulnerable to such culturally blind manipulation by activists imbued with ideological fervour and believing so strongly that they are 'empowering' 'ignorant' peasants that they fail to see their own cultural and political domination. (p. 138)

There is, it seems to us, a danger that L2 students in the reading class may be subjected to the ideology of teachers, whether they be radical feminists, environmentalists, vegetarians, atheists, Picts against Fascism or whatever. In fact, teachers would help more to empower students if they were prepared to 'back off', stopped imposing 'correct' interpretations of texts, let students choose their own texts and set their own agenda.

Cognitive v Social

According to Bernhardt (1991b: 6), 'taking a cognitive perspective means examining the reading process as an intrapersonal problem-solving task that takes place within the brain's knowledge structures'. She notes (p. 8) that the critical element in any cognitive view of reading is that it is an individual act. As a social process, she cites Bloome and Greene (1984): 'reading is used to establish, structure, and maintain social relationships between and among peoples'.

Bernhardt doesn't specify the social aspects except to point out that the same individual and the same text can vary:

the processing of text can be viewed only within a unique cultural context . . . there are basically no generic or generalized readers or reading behaviours . . . there are multiple readers within one person . . . multiple 'texts' within a text. (pp. 10-11)

There are, however, many more factors than this in the social approach to reading.

No text on reading can ignore the social aspects of the activity. Reading, as the studies of literacy mentioned above have made

clear, is a social activity, related always to particular contexts. However, there is no doubt that in comparison to a book like Wallace (1992a) we put more emphasis on the cognitive side. There is more than one reason for this.

1. We consider that the cognitive aspect is primary. Reading without social aspects might be an odd idea, but something like it exists in the experiments of cognitive psychologists, some of whom are mentioned in Chapter 2. Reading without cognitive activity, on the other hand, is simply an impossibility.
2. Wallace remarks, quite correctly, that 'as readers we are frequently addressed in our social roles rather than our personal and individual ones' (1992a: 18) and gives as an example the reader of an advertisement aimed at a social group. We would claim, however, that while this is clearly relevant to an analyst of the text, and certainly relevant to the production of the text, it is not necessarily relevant to readers who probably see themselves as reading the text as individuals. To this extent, reading is always an individual activity. We should not, of course, fall into the trap of equating 'individual' with 'cognitive'; the individuals bring their own societies with them. Nevertheless, there is an element of truth in it – see Bernhardt above.
3. Wallace claims that: 'Classrooms are themselves communities with their own uses of literacy and ascribed roles for teachers and learners.' We agree, but are conscious that the L2 reading class is often a very loose, transitory community, more akin in some ways to the population of an airport lounge. The members have come from different communities and are intending to join different communities. The communities that they plan to join must remain in our consciousness. Again, we see classes as collections of individuals. And if this is true of classrooms, how much more is it true of our other prototypical situation, the examination hall?
4. Finally, in Chapter 4, where we review teaching methods, we try to focus on those areas where empirical evidence exists in support of particular practices. It is our impression that more of such evidence at present exists for those methodologies which have a cognitive, rather than a social focus.

We do, however, try to take the social aspect of reading explicitly into account in our handling of comprehension in Chapter 2, and in the importance we ascribe to authentic tasks and texts in

Chapters 3 and 4. A fuller treatment of the social approach to reading, including activities for the classroom, can be found in Wallace (1992a, 1996).

Organisation of the book

Reading is surprisingly complex to define. Its precise relationship with language in general, and with listening in particular, are a cause of controversy or misunderstanding. So we begin with Chapter 1, 'Preliminaries', in which we attempt to deal with these difficulties.

Chapter 2 is concerned with theoretical issues concerning reading. Here we discuss models of the reading process, including process models, which attempt to model the actual cognitive processes involved in reading, and componential models, which are content to discuss the likely components of the process. In addition, we look at the topics of comprehension, reading skills and strategies.

In Chapters 3 and 4 we proceed to the more applied sections of the book, and examine the testing and teaching of reading. In our accounts of these areas, we have three main aims:

1. To provide a reasonably comprehensive account of the development and current state of the art. We stress the importance of considering expeditious reading strategies (selective, quick and efficient reading activities such as skimming, search reading and scanning) as well as the more conventional careful reading activities.
2. To relate this as far as possible to the theoretical background already discussed. We see this as essentially a two-way issue: one can examine, for example, the justification for testing or teaching practice in terms of theory; conversely, one can examine whether the theory needs to be expanded to take account of some apparently successful or popular practice. Both aspects lead to suggestions for new forms of test and of teaching materials.
3. To provide the reader with guidelines for selecting testing or teaching activities and materials that have some empirical support.

Finally, in the light of our wish to balance theory and practice, we conclude with a chapter on reading research (Chapter 5). Our

aim here is to acquaint the reader with some of the methodology and constraints operating in the research area, by suggesting ways in which readers can construct and carry out their own research in the broad areas of theory, testing and teaching.

Notes

1. Rendell, R. (1977) *A Judgement in Stone*.
2. It is perhaps worth noting that, in our own society, highly literate adults will admit without embarrassment to not being able to 'read' music.
3. Wallace (1996) accepts this, suggesting that critical reading is one strategy available to the reader.

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